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A 10-lane Expressway for Viksit Bharat

The Budget lays a solid foundation for the next few years based on fiscal prudence, public investment, and inclusive growth

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INTERNATIONAL CREDIT RATING AGENCIES ARE BOUND TO TAKE COGNISANCE OF THE STRONG FISCAL FOUNDATION THAT IS SOUGHT TO BE LAID



UDOS TO Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman for formulating a

well-balanced and comprehensive strategy for India's development and economic growth based on the strong pillar of fiscal consolidation. The fiscal deficit target for 2024-25 has been set at 4.9% of GDP. The proposal to bring down the deficit to 4.5% of GDP in 2025-26 shows determination and commitment towards fiscal discipline. At the same time, it is commendable that budgetary capital expenditure has been stepped up to the extent of ₹11.1 lakh crore for infrastructure development and ₹1.48 lakh crore for education, skilling and employment.

With fiscal consolidation being the first priority of the government, nine other priorities have been set out in the Budget speech pertaining to productivity in agriculture, employment and skilling, human resource development, incentivising manufacturing and services sectors, urban development, enhancing energy security, strengthening infrastructure development, providing a boost to research and development, and finally setting out the vision for next-generation reforms.

Well-directed emphasis has been provided for employment generation, entrepreneurship, skilling, and the start-up platform. An amount

of ₹2 lakh crore is proposed to be spent over the next five years which would benefit more than 40 million budding entrepreneurs. The scheme to provide 10 million young Indians with internship prospects at large Indian companies with government support is a momentous step taken by the Finance Minister. The employment-linked incentive scheme for first-time employees blazes a new trail in government policy.

To give a further boost to Indian start-ups, the decision to abolish the so-called 'angel tax' is a welcome step that will foster growth and innovation. Micro, small, and medium enterprises (MSMEs) have been rightly given meaningful incentives that will enable millions of new businesses to take root on a sustainable basis. The overall capital expenditure momentum of the government that started in 2014 will continue, giving a boost to affordable housing, roads and expressways, railways and ports. Investment in infrastructure will be promoted through viability gap funding. A market-based financing framework is to be put in place.

Agriculture and rural development have been given the highest priority. Encouraging farmers to shift to high-priority items like pulses and oilseeds will not only put more purchasing power in their hands but will meet the growing consumer demand for these